

Transposition

Transposition means writing the same music up or down a given interval, and in a different key. This is necessary for certain instruments, which are called transposing instruments.

SEE ALSO

◀ 56–59 Intervals

◀ 64–67 Keys

◀ 72–73 Accidentals

Brass

178–179 ▶

Transposing instruments

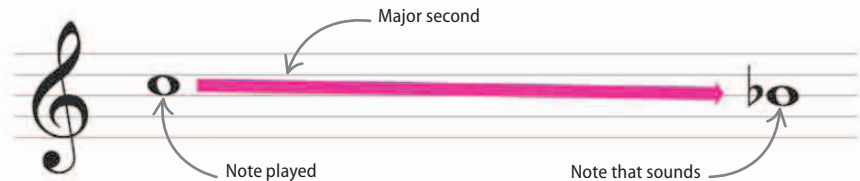
If a note is played on a transposing instrument, the note that will sound is a given interval above—or more usually, below—the note that is played and written on the staff. Some of the most common transposing instruments are the clarinet (in B $\flat$ or A), horn, and alto saxophone. Shown here are the notes that sound if the C above Middle C is played on these instruments.

REAL WORLD

Concert pitch

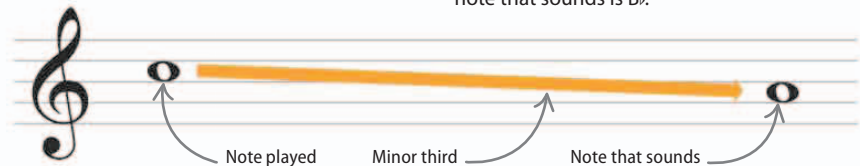
The pitch at which a note sounds is known as “concert pitch.” With transposing instruments, the note that is played or written on the staff is at written pitch, and the note that sounds is at concert pitch. With many instruments, such as the flute, oboe, piano, violin, viola, and cello, the note that is written already sounds at concert pitch.

These are known as nontransposing instruments.



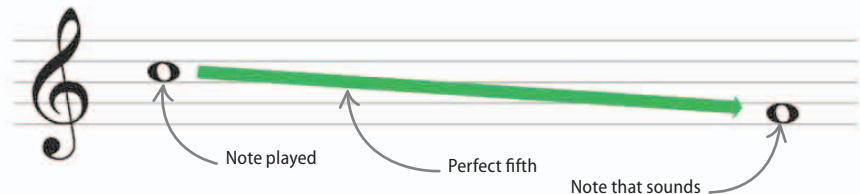
△ Clarinet in B $\flat$

The sounding note on a clarinet in B $\flat$ is a major second below the note that is played. Thus, if a C is played on a clarinet in B $\flat$, the note that sounds is B $\flat$.



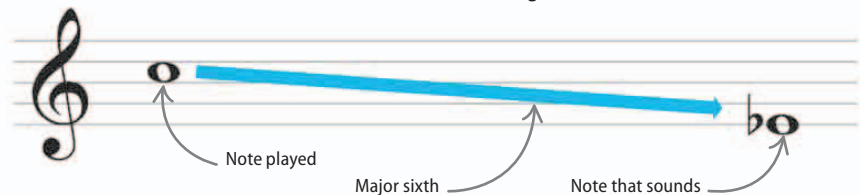
△ Clarinet in A

The note that sounds on a clarinet in A is a minor third below the note that is played. So if a C is played on a clarinet in A, the note that sounds is A.



△ Horn in F

The note that sounds on a horn in F is a perfect fifth below the note that is played. Therefore, if a C is played on a horn in F, the sounding note is F.



△ Alto saxophone in E $\flat$

The note that sounds on an alto saxophone in E $\flat$ is a major sixth below the note that is played. So if a C is played on an alto saxophone in E $\flat$, the note that sounds is E $\flat$.